# ERS

**THERAPY SERVICES:** 
**Physiotherapy, speech and psychiatric therapy, community-based mental health support to rehabilitate patients, aid pain relief**

**PROVIDERS:** **HelpAge, Max@Home, Apollo Home, Fix Health, 2050 Healthcare**
**COST:** **Some are free; others start at Rs 1,000 for an hour of therapy**

**DOCTOR VISITS:** 
**For consultations, providing diagnosis and treatment at home**

**PROVIDERS:** **Portea, Emoha, Max@Home, Apollo Homecare, Kyno Health, Mobile Healthcare Vans run by government/ NGOs**
**COST:** **Starting at Rs 1,000 for a general physician visit**

## BENEFITS OF HOME HEALTHCARE

### FOR PATIENTS

- Emotional and physical comfort of being at home
- Reduced risk of hospital-acquired infections
- Less risk of re-hospitalisation
- Cost-effective care, especially for long-term needs of elderly
- Anxiety-free, instant diagnostic services like ECG, dialysis, CT scan, X-rays

### FOR HOSPITALS

- Reduced burden on beds, especially ICUs
- Improved patient satisfaction
- A longer-term patient relationship
- Reduced hospital overhead costs
- Better management of post-surgery recovery and diseases like hypertension, diabetes, chronic heart disease through closely monitored care

even nurses and midwives can use them without additional radiology training. The gadgets do it all—monitoring parameters, body scanning and medical analysis. Doorstep X-rays, ultrasounds and even some MRIs can be performed at home by providers like Scan4Health, Apollo Home, Max@Home and Healthians.

An ageing population and increasing incidence of lifestyle diseases make the concept of 'healthcare anywhere' a promising investment. "Hospitals are strained and diseases that can be treated successfully at home need not take up unnecessary bedspace," says Lathwal. This is crucial, for India's hospital bed-to-population ratio is currently at 1.3 beds per 1,000 people, against a recommended three beds.

Investing in homecare instead of building new hospitals makes business sense too. The CMR report revealed that home healthcare could replace up to 20 per cent of hospital operational costs. You don't need an X-ray for these results to make sense. With over 245,000 patients served annually and Q4 FY25 revenue growth of 22 per cent, MAX@Home has plans to expand operations.

Public healthcare is not lagging behind. Over 60 million nationwide e-consults were done till 2021 across the government-supported telehealth infrastructure. With access to digital health records, doctors could treat patients over the phone. The Centre has also been rolling out its flagship 'Aarogya-Doctors on Wheels'—an AI supported telemedicine mobile clinic that reaches out to patients. A patient gives details of her illness in her native language to the AI doctor, who responds in the same language. Afterwards, she is connected to a super specialist through various hospital tie-ups and given a free-of-cost prescription.

Trained caregivers are an attraction too. While previously, there was no formal skills validation for home caregivers, today firms train staff on infection control, empathy, medical hygiene and emergency handling. Apollo Home, for example, also invests in staff safety through pre-deployment risk assessment of a home and an SOS alert system.

To ensure family members understand a patient's needs, firms provide them detailed counselling on medical adherence and maintaining daily logs to track compliance with the care plan. Around 60-80 per cent of home health needs are for senior citizens. "The elderly require compassionate listening, understanding and care," says Dr Ritu Rana, mission head-healthcare, HelpAge India. Home healthcare providers now have specially trained nurses and senior citizen-friendly plans. "I have been using a senior first programme and I have never felt safer and happier," says 71-year-old Amruta Nair, a homemaker in Bengaluru. Her nurse looks after her emotional and medical needs and in case of an emergency, is skilled to call the right doctors.

Homecare is here to stay, just like quick commerce and work from home. A room of one's own is now also a place of regular medical care and recuperation. ■